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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1998-1999

Coverage Date: 1930 AD - 1999 AD

Place Coverage

Mgeta and Nyandira, Mvomero, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): Rainmaking In Mgeta

On the morning that the beer was ready, Lamba took the beer and his ritual medicines and went with a few select assistants to conduct his *tambiko* at four sacred places on the mountain where his ancestors from four clans were buried. Some of these ritual places are marked by stones, in others there are sacred groves. At these places, his *makili*, Lamba would clean his ancestors' graves (*kufagia* "to sweep") and would entreaty the spirits to bring rain. At one point a chicken would be slaughtered, prepared, and eaten by any joking partners who were present. (Mbagho's *tambiko* always included the killing of a black sheep representing the black clouds of rain, and it is said in Mgeta that this signifies his highest rank among the local rainmakers.)

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It is widely agreed that while Lamba was accompanied by one or two adults who were joking partners, his main assistants in this *tambiko* were children. This was described as consisting of one boy and one girl, or two boys and two girls. These children helped with fetching water to use in the rites. According to [266](#) three elders, children must be present because “they are angels,” “they are the ones who may ask God to grant this,” “they do not have any blame, they don't have wrongs, the same as angels.” As to why both boys and girls would be involved, one elder stated, “The way that they want it, you know tradition, tradition of long ago, *tambiko* is with a husband and wife.” This mention of the specific symbolic relationship between husband and wife is particularly important, especially as it came from an individual who everyone said was the only person who was closely connected to Lamba. In a different area of Mgeta I was told that rainmaking did not involve children, but instead the rainmaker would be always be accompanied by an adult woman joking partner (there is a linkage between clans with preferential marriage and those in which joking relationships occur). Again, there is an important relevance of gender to the ceremony, this time in the sense of a positive, productive combination of the efforts of “husband and wife.”

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